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AUTO

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Four cars, four flavours: Here's what we drove last month

MINI Cooper D: Poetry in Motion

The MINI Cooper D has racing DNA deeply ingrained within; a go kart-like stance moulded into a suave, new age design. MINI follows a circular design from the headlamp and overall chassis to the interior buttons, vents, controls and practically everything, and this lends smooth continuity to the car on overall terms. Not only does this make the car look suave and sporty, it also aids in aerodynamics, which leads to superior handling and great in-cabin experience.

The highlight of the interiors is the infotainment panel. The 8.8-inch display deftly lets go of its touchscreen interface and relies on the circular iDrive controller for all controls. The intuitive controller gets seven buttons for quick access

to multimedia, radio, telephone and sat-nav, along with main menu, back and settings. At the centre is a large circular control dial with five-way toggle and a central touchpad.



This is particularly helpful when you're adding destinations to maps, searching for contacts or dialling a number – you can simply sketch on the dial with your finger to represent the alphabet/number. There are plenty of LEDs at play here, with exterior welcome lights and a glorious multi-colour LED ring surrounding the central display. The LED ring inside changes colour based on what is on the display, and hence works functionally as well as aesthetically. The rest of the buttons and the sporty instrument cluster get red LED lighting, and you also get electrically operated seats with great body support.

All of this is topped by the drive characteristics. Despite the rather limited 115hp of power, the MINI Cooper D's engine is tuned very well, and the heavy steering wheel offers great, precise feedback. Switch to Sport and you immediately feel the surge of well-optimised power – which sums up the entire range of emotions and class of this premium hatch.

Volkswagen Beetle: The iconic look

If there's any car that can really make heads turn wherever it goes, it is the Volkswagen Beetle. Dating way back to the WWII era, the Beetle has stood the test of time to maintain



its legendary status as an icon. The latest edition is all about making the Beetle smarter than ever before, while retaining its iconic design, a pleasantly voluptuous cabin and generously smooth driving dynamics.

Powered by Volkswagen's SmartLink infotainment system that packages Android Auto, Apple CarPlay and MirrorLink into an adaptive icon, you get ample gizmos to play around with. The SmartLink console misses out on a dedicated sat-nav unit, but presents music and telephony via Bluetooth. You also get a USB port to charge devices, an aux port for analogue audio connectivity, and an SD card and a CD drive should you require such media. The system also gets integrated voice operation that works well with the preset commands.